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English

Unit I Trials and Triumphs

- *A Very Old Man With Enormous Wings*
- *In the Attic*
- *"Friends, Romans, Countrymen..."*

A VERY OLD MAN WITH ENORMOUS WINGS -GABRIEL GRACIA MARQUEZ

Comprehension – Textual Passage

1.Read the passage from A Very Old Man with Enormous Wings and answer the questions that follow. (5 × 1 = 5)

Pelayo had to go very close to see what was moving and groaning in the rear of the courtyard. It was an old man lying face down in the mud. In spite of his tremendous efforts, he could not get up because his enormous wings were entangled in the mud. Frightened by the sight, Pelayo ran to get Elisenda, his wife. The man was dressed like a ragpicker. His huge buzzard wings were dirty and half-plucked, and his pitiful condition took away any sense of grandeur he might have had.

They looked at him so long and so closely that soon they overcame their surprise and dared to speak to him. He answered in an incomprehensible dialect with a strong sailor's voice. They concluded that he was a lonely castaway from some foreign ship wrecked by the storm. But a neighbour woman corrected them at once and said, "He's an angel. He must have been coming for the child."

Questions

1. Where was the old man lying?
2. Why was the old man unable to get up?
3. What did Pelayo and Elisenda first think the old man was?
4. "His pitiful condition took away any sense of grandeur he might have had." What does this sentence suggest about the old man?
5. Choose the correct option:

The neighbour woman called the old man an angel because

i) he had enormous wings

ii) he was rich and powerful

iii) he looked unusual and mysterious

iv) he spoke like a sailor

A) i and ii

B) i and iii
C) ii and iv
D) Only iii

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2.Read the following passage from A Very Old Man with Enormous Wings and answer the questions that follow. (5 × 1 = 5)

The angel was the only one who took no part in his own act. He spent his time trying to get comfortable in his borrowed nest. His only supernatural virtue seemed to be patience. He was patient when the hens pecked at him, searching for parasites in his wings. He was patient when the cripples pulled out his feathers to touch their limbs. He remained patient even when people threw stones at him to make him rise and stand.

After many days of suffering, his condition slowly began to improve. New, stiff feathers grew on his wings. One morning Elisenda saw him making his first attempts at flight. At first, they were clumsy and uncertain, but finally he managed to rise into the air and fly away. Elisenda watched him until he disappeared on the horizon and felt a great sense of relief.

Questions

1. What is described as the angel's only supernatural virtue?
A) Power
B) Wisdom
C) Patience
D) Beauty

2. How did the angel react to the cruel behaviour of the people?
A) By escaping immediately
B) By becoming angry
C) By remaining calm and patient
D) By attacking them

3. The phrase "borrowed nest" refers to:
A) A tree
B) The chicken coop
C) A ship
D) A cave

4. Pick out the word from the passage that means "awkward or unsteady".

5. The angel's final flight symbolises:
i) Freedom from suffering
ii) Triumph of patience
iii) Return of strength
iv) Revenge on humans
Choose the correct option:
A) i, ii and iii
B) i and iv
C) ii and iv
D) Only iii

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3. Read the passage from A Very Old Man with Enormous Wings and answer the questions that follow. (5 × 1 = 5)

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On the following day everyone knew that a flesh-and-blood angel was being kept in Pelayo's house. The news spread rapidly and soon the courtyard had the bustle of a marketplace. People came from far and wide to see the angel. Some were curious, some came hoping for miracles and healing. The most unfortunate invalids on earth arrived in search of health. Pelayo and Elisenda had to call in troops to control the crowd.

They soon got the idea of fencing in the yard and charging five cents for admission to see the angel. The curious kept coming in large numbers. In less than a week, Pelayo and Elisenda had filled their rooms with money. Still, the long line of visitors waiting to see the angel stretched beyond the horizon.

Questions

1 What happened to the courtyard after the news spread?

2.Why did people come from far and wide to see the angel?

3. How did Pelayo and Elisenda try to control the crowd?

4. "In less than a week, Pelayo and Elisenda had filled their rooms with money."

What does this sentence suggest about their attitude towards the angel?

5. Choose the correct option:

Pelayo and Elisenda fenced their yard and charged money mainly because

i) they wanted to make profit

ii) they wanted to protect the angel

iii) they were disturbed by the huge crowd

iv) they wanted to help the poor

A) i and iii

B) ii and iv

C) i and iv

D) Only i

4.Read the passage from A Very Old Man with Enormous Wings by Gabriel García Márquez and answer the questions that follow. (5 × 1 = 5)

After the rain stopped, Pelayo went into the courtyard and found an old man lying face down in the mud. He was dressed like a beggar and had enormous wings, dirty and half-plucked. At first Pelayo thought he was a castaway from a shipwreck. But when he turned him over, he saw the wings clearly. The old man spoke in an incomprehensible dialect and seemed very weak. Elisenda and Pelayo were confused and frightened. A neighbour woman told them that he was an angel who had come to take away their sick child, but he was too old and weak to carry out his task.

They locked him in a chicken coop. Soon people from nearby villages came to see the strange creature. Some treated him kindly, others poked him and threw food at him as if he were an animal. The angel bore everything with patience and indifference. His only human quality seemed to be his endless sadness.

Questions

1.Where did Pelayo find the old man?

A) Inside the house

B) In the chicken coop

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C) In the courtyard, lying in the mud

D) On the seashore

2. Why were Pelayo and Elisenda confused and frightened?

A) Because the old man was violent

B) Because he spoke their language clearly

C) Because he had enormous wings and looked strange

D) Because he asked for money

3. The neighbour woman believed the old man was:

A) A beggar

B) A magician

C) An angel

D) A sailor

4. Pick out the word from the passage that means “not understandable”.

5. “The angel bore everything with patience and indifference.”

This shows that the angel was:

i) Angry

ii) Calm

iii) Tolerant

iv) Violent

Choose the correct option:

A) i and ii

B) ii and iii

C) i and iv

D) Only ii

ANSWERS

SET 1

1. He was lying in the mud in the rear of the courtyard.

2. He was unable to get up because his enormous wings were entangled in the mud.

3. They thought he was a lonely castaway from a shipwreck.

4. It suggests that though he might have been a majestic or divine being, his weak and miserable appearance made him look ordinary and helpless.

5. B (i and iii)

SET 2

1. C Patience

2. C by remaining calm and patient

3. B The chicken coop

4.clumsy

4. A

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SET 3

1.The courtyard became crowded and noisy like a marketplace.
2.People came hoping to see the angel and to be cured of their illnesses or problems.
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3.They fenced the yard and charged five cents for admission to manage the crowd.
4.It suggests that they became greedy and started treating the angel as a source of income.
5. 5A (i and iii)

SET 4

1.C
2.C
3.C
4.incomprehensible
5.B

DISCOURSES

1. "A Very Old Man with Enormous Wings is a story that exposes human selfishness and highlights the importance of compassion and empathy."
Prepare a review of the lesson bringing out its theme, the character of the angel, the attitude of Pelayo and Elisenda, and the message conveyed by the author.

A very Old Man with Enormous Wings by Gabriel García Márquez is a powerful and symbolic story that explores human behaviour, compassion, cruelty, and the way society treats those who are different. Through the character of the old man with wings, the author presents a deep criticism of human selfishness and lack of empathy.

The story begins when Pelayo and Elisenda find an old man lying helplessly in their courtyard. His enormous wings make him appear strange and mysterious, yet his weak and miserable condition makes him look more human than divine. Instead of treating him with kindness and care, the couple and the villagers see him as an object of curiosity. This shows how people are often more interested in the unusual than in the suffering of others.

At first, there is confusion about whether the old man is an angel. Some expect miracles from him. When their expectations are not fulfilled, their interest slowly fades. Pelayo and Elisenda exploit the situation by fencing their yard and charging money from visitors. The angel is treated like a circus animal, and people throw stones at him, pull his feathers, and disturb him constantly. This reflects how society often uses the weak and the helpless for personal benefit instead of protecting them.

The angel's character stands in sharp contrast to the cruelty of humans. His greatest supernatural quality is patience. He silently tolerates all kinds of suffering without anger or revenge. His

endurance makes him a symbol of quiet dignity and forgiveness. Through him, Márquez shows that true greatness lies in tolerance and compassion rather than power or authority.

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The story also criticizes blind faith and shallow beliefs. People are quick to believe in miracles but lose interest when the angel does not satisfy their expectations. The arrival of the spider woman proves that people prefer simple and entertaining stories to deep and meaningful truths. This highlights the superficial nature of human curiosity.

The ending of the story is highly symbolic. When the angel finally regains strength and flies away, Elisenda feels relieved, not because he is free, but because he is no longer a burden to her life. This shows her selfish attitude and lack of emotional connection. The angel's flight represents freedom from suffering and the triumph of patience over cruelty.

In conclusion, the lesson teaches that kindness and empathy are essential qualities in life. It warns us against judging others based on appearance and exploiting those who are weak. The story encourages us to develop compassion and humanity, reminding us that even small act of kindness can bring hope and light into the lives of others.

2. Imagine that you are a student who read A Very Old Man with Enormous Wings. You are deeply moved by the suffering and patience of the angel. Write **a letter** to your friend explaining what the story taught you about kindness, compassion, and the way society treats the weak and different.

xyz Class X
Govt. High School
24 January 2026

Dear Riya,

I hope you are doing well. I wanted to share my thoughts with you after reading the lesson A Very Old Man with Enormous Wings. It touched me deeply and made me think about how we treat others in our society.

The story shows how an old man with wings, who might be an angel, is treated very cruelly by people. Instead of showing love and care, they treat him like a strange object or a circus animal. Even Pelayo and Elisenda use him to make money. This made me realise how selfish human beings can become when they see an opportunity for profit.

What impressed me most was the patience of the angel. Even when people threw stones at him, pulled his feathers, or locked him in a chicken coop, he never showed anger. His patience teaches us that true greatness lies in tolerance and forgiveness.He silently endured all suffering without hatred.

This lesson taught me that we should always be kind and compassionate, especially towards those who are weak, different, or helpless. We should never judge others by their appearance. Small acts of kindness can bring hope to someone's life.

I feel this story has changed the way I look at people around me. I hope we can always try to be more humane and understanding.

With love,

Yours affectionately
XYZreading the

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3. Elisenda saw the old man with enormous wings fly away at last. Though he was no longer a burden to her, the moment made her think deeply. That night she wrote her feelings in her diary. Write the likely diary entry.

24 January 2026

Today was a strange and unforgettable day. The old man with wings finally flew away. For a long time he had been a part of our lives, though we never treated him like a human being. When I saw him rising slowly into the sky, my first feeling was relief. He was no longer our responsibility, no longer an annoyance in our courtyard.

But as I stood there watching him disappear on the horizon, I felt something else too. A quiet guilt filled my heart. Did we really treat him with kindness? We locked him in a chicken coop, allowed people to hurt him, and even made money out of his misery. He suffered silently, showing nothing but patience.

He was never cruel or angry, though we gave him so many reasons to be. Today I realised that he might truly have been an angel, not because of his wings, but because of his tolerance and forgiveness. I don't know if I should feel happy or ashamed. Perhaps both. I only hope that wherever he is now, he is free from pain and suffering. I wish we had been kinder to him.

4. Prepare a character sketch of the angel in A Very Old Man with Enormous Wings, bringing out his physical appearance, qualities, and symbolic significance in the story.

The angel is the most striking and symbolic character in the story. Though he has enormous wings, he does not appear majestic or divine. Instead, he looks weak, old, and miserable. His physical appearance contrasts sharply with our traditional idea of an angel. He is dressed like a ragpicker, dirty and half-plucked, which makes people doubt his identity.

The most important quality of the angel is his patience. Even when he is locked in a chicken coop, poked by curious visitors, and treated like a circus animal, he never protests or shows anger. People throw stones at him, pull his feathers, and disturb him constantly, yet he endures everything silently. His tolerance and calmness make him morally superior to the humans around him.

The angel also symbolizes suffering and endurance. He becomes a victim of human cruelty, greed, and ignorance. While the villagers exploit him for money and entertainment, he remains indifferent to fame or attention. His only concern seems to be survival.

Though people see him as strange and useless, he shows a quiet dignity. His eventual recovery and flight suggest hope and freedom. His escape represents liberation from suffering and the triumph of patience over cruelty.

Thus, the angel is not great because of his wings, but because of his endurance, humility, and forgiveness. He teaches us that true divinity lies in compassion, patience, and silent strength rather than in power or appearance.

5. The angel in Pelayo's courtyard attracted a large crowd and created great excitement in the village. Prepare **a newspaper** report on the incident, highlighting how the old man was discovered, the reaction of the people, and the response of Pelayo and Elisenda.

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Angel Found in Village Courtyard Creates Sensation
By Staff Reporter

Coastal Village, January 24 :
A strange and sensational incident shocked the residents of our coastal village yesterday when an old man with enormous wings was found lying in the muddy courtyard of a local house. Pelayo, a villager, discovered the unusual man while returning home after the rain.

According to eyewitnesses, the old man was weak, dirty, and unable to stand because his large wings were entangled in the mud. At first, he was believed to be a castaway from a shipwreck. Later, a neighbour identified him as an angel, which added to the mystery and excitement.

Soon, people from nearby villages rushed to Pelayo's house to catch a glimpse of the "angel." The courtyard turned into a crowded marketplace. Some visitors came out of curiosity, while others hoped for miracles and healing. Pelayo and his wife, Elisenda, fenced their yard and began charging a small fee for entry to control the crowd.

Though the angel showed no aggression and remained calm and patient, many visitors treated him like an object of entertainment. The incident has raised serious questions about human compassion and the way society treats the weak and different.

Authorities have urged people to remain calm and behave responsibly. The event has become a topic of widespread discussion, reminding everyone of the need for kindness and humanity.

6. After reading A Very Old Man with Enormous Wings, two students discuss the lesson and its message. Write the likely conversation between them. Conversation

Anu: Did you finish reading A Very Old Man with Enormous Wings?
Ravi: Yes, I did. It made me feel sad for the old man. People treated him so badly.
Anu: True. Instead of helping him, they locked him in a chicken coop and made money from him.
Ravi: What impressed me most was his patience. He never complained or showed anger.
Anu: That shows his true greatness. Humans were cruel, but he was full of tolerance.
Ravi: Pelayo and Elisenda were selfish. They thought only about their profit.
Anu: Yes, and even at the end, Elisenda felt relieved because he was gone, not because he was free.
Ravi: The story really teaches us to be kind to those who are weak or different.
Anu: Exactly. Compassion is more important than curiosity or profit.

PHRASAL VERBS
1. take away – remove something or someone from a place.
Eg: This took away any sense of grandeur he might have had.
2. call in – visit someone briefly or request someone's presence.
Eg: Then they called in a neighbour to see him.
3. knock down – demolish or hit something so it falls.

Eg:" He must have been coming for the child, but the poor fellow is so old that the rain knocked him down."
4. watch over – take care of or guard someone/something.
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Eg: Pelayo watched over him all afternoon from the kitchen, armed with his bailiff's club.
5. pull out – withdraw from an activity or leave a place
Eg: He was patient again when the cripples pulled out his feathers to touch their limbs with.
6. set up – arrange, establish, or start something (like a business).
Eg: Pelayo also set up a rabbit warren and gave up his job as a bailiff for good.
7. give up – stop trying; surrender.
Eg: Pelayo also set up a rabbit warren and gave up his job as a bailiff for good.
8. get used to – become familiar or comfortable with something.
Eg: But then they began to lose their fears and got used to the smell.
9. come down – decrease, fall, or descend.
Eg: They both came down with the chicken pox at the same time.
10. fall apart – break into pieces or emotionally collapse.
Eg: Before the child got his second tooth, he'd gone inside the chicken coop to play, as the wires were falling
apart.
11. take care of – look after or be responsible for someone/something.
Eg: The doctor who took care of the child couldn't resist the temptation to listen to the angel's heart.
12. go about – begin or continue doing something in a certain way.
Eg: He could scarcely eat, and his eyes had also become so foggy that he went about bumping into posts.
13. throw over – end a relationship or abandon someone.
Eg: Pelayo threw a blanket over him and let him sleep in the shed.
14. let out – allow to leave; release (a person or sound).
Eg: Elisenda let out a sigh of relief, for herself and for him, when she watched him pass over the last houses.
15. pass over – ignore or not choose someone/something.
Eg: Elisenda let out a sigh of relief, for herself and for him, when she watched him pass over the last houses.
16. hold oneself up – remain strong or maintain oneself (physically or emotionally).
Eg: He was holding himself up in some way with the risky flapping of a senile vulture.
17. keep on – continue doing something.
Eg: She kept on watching until it was no longer possible for her to see him.

LANGUAGE ELEMENTS UNIT 1

1.Pick out the **Noun Phrase** in the subject position and **Verb phrase** in the sentence that follows.

A. All kinds of rumours spread over the small town.
B. 'His pitiful condition seemed that of a drenched great-grandfather.
C. All she needed was one look to show them their mistakes.
D. The gesture instils in him confidence and a renewed hope for survival.
E. His only supernatural virtue seemed to be patience.

2. Complete the dialogue suitably:
Elisenda: It seems you are frightened, ----a----------?
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Pelayo : Yes dear, a little bit.
Elisenda: ----------b--------------------?
Pelayo : I saw something moving in the courtyard.
Elisenda:--------------c---------------?
Pelayo : No, I couldn't see it clearly as it was dark there. If you bring a torch, --------d----------.
Elisenda: You had better----------e----------. I will bring a torch.
Pelayo : No, I don't want to wait here alone. We will go together.
Elisenda: Ok.

3.Read the given dialogue and complete the sentences given below:
Elisenda : Why are you frightened?
Pelayo : I saw somebody lying in the courtyard.
Elisenda asked ----------a----------
Pelayo replied ----------b----------
4,Edit the given passage.
When I placed my fingers in (a) the keyboard, they shook. I hadn't pracise (b) for two and a half years, my fingers was (c)stiff and covered with a thick layer of dirt, but (d) I had not cut my nails for some weeks.

5.Complete the given passage by choosing the suitable words given in brackets.
She stared -------(a) me, dropped her bundle and took to ----(b) heels with a shriek of, "A German!" Immediately ----------(c) guard turned, saw me, aimed ----------(d) fired her machine pistol. I rushed -------- (e) the stairs and took refuge in the attic.

Answers.

1

A. . NP: All kinds of rumours VP : spread over the small town.

B. NP: His pitiful condition. VP: seemed that of a drenched great-grandfather .

C. NP : All she needed VP : was one look to show them their mistakes.

D. NP : The gesture VP : instils in him confidence and a renewed hope for survival.

E. NP: His only supernatural virtue VP : seemed to be patience.

2.

a. doesn't it?
b. What happened?
c. Could you see it clearly?
d. We can see properly.
e. Wait here

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3. a.why he was frightened.
b.that he had seen somebody lying in the courtyard.
4.a) On
b) Practised
c) Were
d) And
5. a.at,
b. her,
c. the,
d. and ,
e. up

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